

audiences through satellite TV and, recently, YouTube. Meanwhile, their storytelling style was also getting accepted theatrically. “The biggest Hindi blockbusters of Akshay Kumar and Salman Khan from 2007-12 were remakes of south Indian films,” says Amit Sharma, MD of Miraj Cinemas. When *Pushpa*, *RRR* and *KGF2* burst on to the screens in quick succession with substantial marketing and heroes who had been accepted by the masses, the parched audiences found an oasis in the desert. “Until now, we had some misconceptions that these kinds of films don’t do well in multiplexes. Classy films may not be liked by the mass audience. But massy films will be liked by the class audience,” says Mythri’s Shankar.



NOW THAT THE Vindhyas no longer pose an imposing barrier for films to travel across, the scope of the business is expanding. For one, theatre owners are a happy lot over higher chances of profits. “Whether Hindi, Telugu, Tamil or Kannada, they are creating stronger content. Earlier, out of 52 weeks in a year, you would expect 15-20 weeks

It’s also amply aided by the pandemic-accelerated trend of OTTs buying digital rights of films at hefty rates before their theatrical release. Increasingly, the non-theatrical rights decide the film’s financial fate. The box office collection is just the icing on the cake. For example, Kamal Haasan-starrer *Vikram*, made on an estimated budget of ₹150 crore, earned around ₹100 crore through the pre-sale of satellite and digital rights. “Non-theatrical rights are covering 50-75 per cent and occasionally even 100 per cent of your cost, depending on whether it is a big- or medium budget film,” says Yarlagaadda. So, a film producer’s risk appetite increases because he knows he can recoup 50 per cent investment from other avenues, says Sharma. “That incentivises the content maker to make bigger budget films, which eventually yield better BO numbers.” Plus, OTTs can also cultivate a global audience for Indian films and open up untapped markets much like what TV did for Allu Arjun and *Pushpa* in the North. “Our overseas box office collection is a minuscule number. We only screen films where we have Indian diaspora such as Australia, New Zealand, the Middle-East, the UK and North America. What about eastern European and Latin American markets?” asks Sharma.

As the seeds have been sown for all kinds of cross pollinations, interesting collaborations are already taking shape. For instance, *RRR* (Ajay Devgn, Alia Bhatt) and *KGF2* (Raveena Tandon, Sanjay Dutt) already

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to do well. Now, the expectation is 26-30 weeks,” says Dhishoom’s Dhingra. Second, it has laid threadbare the opportunity for multiplexes and single-screens to go deeper into India. Exhibitors in Tier II and III towns are opting for 3D screens and Dolby Atmos sound, says distributor Meh-ta. “They realise these are the films you can fight an OTT with. To get the audience back to the theatres, you have to give them something they cannot get at home.”

More importantly, film budgets are ballooning. “Not for every film. For a few, yes, especially those with pan-India appeal,” says Yarlagaadda. Agreeing, Shankar estimates *Pushpa 2* will require ₹500 crore. Miraj Cinemas’ Sharma sees films getting made on ₹500-600 crore budgets more commonly now. “The recovery of the film was the reason for making it within a certain budget. From here on, a content maker can take the production cost to the next level and we can compete with Hollywood.”

showcased Bollywood star power. More are following suit: *KGF*’s Director and Producer Prashanth Neel and Hombale Films are teaming up with Prabhas for Telugu film *Salaar*. Shah Rukh Khan’s upcoming film *Jawan* is directed by Tamil director Atlee and co-stars Nayanthara. Vijay Sethupathi and Katrina Kaif are uniting for *Merry Christmas*. “Bollywood faces like Dutt, Devgn, Bhatt, etc., were a part of pan-India films so that north Indian audiences could relate to a known face. But there’s no formula. For example, neither of the *Baahubali* movies have a north Indian face and still it did well,” says Kiragandur. However, he sees this as the way forward. “We have to walk together, there’s no language barrier now. It’s an Indian movie.”

One is tempted to say “Amen”. **BT**

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